freee Approval Workflow

Benchmark Analysis Report

Research Date: December 2025

1. Executive Summary

freee provides a comprehensive approval workflow system integrated with their accounting and expense management platform. The system supports purchase requests (購買申請), expense claims, payment requests, and general workflow applications. Key differentiators include automatic route selection based on amount/position, deep integration with accounting data, and flexible form customization.

2. Product Overview

2.1 Target Plans

The approval workflow functionality is available in freee's higher-tier plans:

- **Corporate:** Advance and Enterprise plans (formerly Professional/Enterprise)
- **Individual:** Premium plan
- **Add-ons:** freee支出管理 (Expense Management Plus/Full)

2.2 Application Types

freee distinguishes between two main workflow categories:

- **Purchase Requests (購買申請):** For payment-related approvals such as procurement, travel expenses, and entertainment expenses
- **General Applications (各種申請):** For non-payment workflows like contract approvals, seal requests, and general proposals

3. Form Creation & Customization

3.1 Pre-built Templates

freee provides standard templates that can be customized:

- Proposal/Ringi (稟議書)
- Seal/Stamp Request (押印申請)
- Contract Application (契約申請)
- Purchase Request (購買申請)

3.2 Form Field Types

Custom fields support multiple input formats:

Field Type	Description
Text / Multi-line Text	Free-form text entry for descriptions, notes
Amount (金額)	Numeric field for monetary values, supports tax calculations
Date	Date picker for occurrence date, payment date, etc.
Selection / Dropdown	Predefined options for categories, types, vendors

Field Type	Description
File Attachment	Upload quotes, contracts, receipts (up to 10 files, 5MB each)
Vendor/Counterparty	Linked to vendor master data with auto-completion

Key Configuration Options:

- Required/Optional field designation
- Show/Hide fields based on form purpose
- Remarks/Notes field with optional usage
- Integration with File Box for document management

4. Approval Route Configuration

4.1 Route Definition

Approval routes define the sequence and conditions for approvals:

- **Multi-step Approval:** Configure multiple sequential approval stages (e.g., Section Chief → Department Head → Executive)
- **Approver Types:** Specific users, department/position combinations, or role-based assignment
- **OR Approval:** Any one of multiple designated approvers can approve to advance the step
- **Per-Form Routes:** Different forms can use different routes or route selections

4.2 Automatic Route Branching

Amount-Based Branching (金額分岐)

Routes automatically switch based on total amount thresholds:

Amount Threshold	Approval Route
¥300,000 or more	Section Chief → Manager → Department Head
¥100,000 - ¥299,999	Section Chief → Manager
Under ¥100,000	Section Chief only

Position-Based Branching (役職分岐)

Routes adjust based on the applicant's position:

- Regular employees may require full approval chain
- Managers may skip initial approval stages
- Executives may have self-approval rights

Note: Amount and position branching can be combined using AND conditions.

4.3 Department/Position Integration

Routes integrate with freee Human Resources (人事労務) for:

- Automatic approver assignment based on applicant's department
- Hierarchical routing (e.g., 'applicant's department manager')
- Parent department escalation for cross-department approvals

5. Status & Operations Management

5.1 Application Statuses

Status	Description
Draft (下書き)	Application saved but not submitted; editable by applicant

Status	Description
Pending (申請中)	Submitted and awaiting approval at current stage
Awaiting My Approval	Pending approval specifically from the logged-in user
Returned (差戻し)	Sent back to applicant for revision; can be edited and resubmitted
Rejected (却下)	Denied by approver; can be changed to 'Returned' by admin
Approved (承認済)	All approval stages completed; triggers downstream actions

5.2 Approval Operations

1. **Approve (承認):** Advances to next stage or completes if final
2. **Return (差戻し):** Sends back to applicant with comments for revision
3. **Reject (却下):** Denies the application; comment required
4. **Proxy Approve (代理承認):** Admin or designated proxy approves on behalf of assigned approver
5. **Cancel Approval:** Admin can reverse approval and return to applicant (requires admin rights)
6. **Batch Approve:** Approve up to 50 applications at once (with certain restrictions)

6. Proxy Approval System

6.1 Proxy Approval Types

- **Designated Proxy:** Specific user assigned as backup for an approver
- **Admin Override:** Administrators with appropriate privileges can approve any pending request
- **Privileged Approver:** Special permission allowing view and approval of all applications company-wide

6.2 Configuration

Set via [Application Settings] → [Approval Routes/Proxy Approval] → [Proxy Approval] tab. One proxy approver can be designated per original approver. Proxy settings apply across all workflow types, not per-route.

7. Notification System

7.1 Notification Channels

Channel	Capabilities
Email	Primary channel for all workflow events; requires email verification
Slack	Direct messages for pending approvals; requires workspace integration
Mobile App	Push notifications via freee iOS/Android apps
In-App	Notification bell icon showing pending action count

7.2 Notification Triggers

1. New application submitted → Next approver notified
2. Application approved → Applicant and next approver (if any) notified
3. Application returned → Applicant notified with comments
4. Application rejected → Applicant notified with rejection reason
5. Comment added → All parties (applicant + approvers) notified
6. Application canceled → Relevant approvers notified

8. File & Document Management

File Box (ファイルボックス) Integration:

Documents uploaded to applications are stored in freee's File Box with the following features:

Feature	Details
Supported Formats	PDF, JPEG, PNG, GIF, Word, Excel, CSV, ZIP
Size Limits	5MB per file; up to 10 attachments per application
OCR Processing	Automatic text extraction from receipts/invoices
Legal Compliance	Electronic bookkeeping law (電子帳簿保存法) compliant storage
Edit History	Automatic versioning and change tracking
Search	By issuer, date, amount for regulatory compliance

9. Permission & Access Control

9.1 Standard Roles

Role	Permissions
Administrator	Full access: route config, all applications, proxy approval, cancel approvals
General (Accounting)	Create/view own applications, proxy approval capability, Excel import
Approval/Application	Create/view own applications, approve assigned items
View Only	Read-only access to applications

Custom Roles: Enterprise plan allows creating custom permission sets by copying and modifying standard roles.

10. Audit & Logging

10.1 Event Logging (Enterprise Only)

Enterprise plans include comprehensive event logging with:

Log Type	Contents
Event Logs	All operations with timestamps, exportable as TXT/ZIP
Login History	User login/logout records with IP, exportable to CSV
Permission History	Changes to user permissions and roles
Operation History	Per-document actions viewable in document detail screens

10.2 Data Export

Application data can be exported as CSV with search filters applied. Export history is maintained for re-download. Character encoding options: UTF-8 or Shift-JIS.

11. Integration Points

Key integrations within the freee ecosystem:

Integration	Function
freee会計 (Accounting)	Auto-create transactions from approved requests
freee人事労務 (HR)	Department/position data for route assignment
freeeサイン (e-Signature)	Send contracts for electronic signature post-approval
Payment Processing	Generate payment files (FB data) for bank transfers
Slack/Chatwork	Real-time notifications and reminders

12. Recommendations for Implementation

Based on freee's implementation, the following features should be prioritized:

12.1 Core Features (Must Have)

These align with your requirements and are fundamental to freee's system:

1. **Multi-step approval routes** with configurable stages
2. **Amount-based automatic route branching** (金額分岐)
3. **Status workflow:** Draft → Pending → Returned/Rejected → Approved
4. **Proxy approval** with admin override capability
5. **Multi-channel notifications** (Email, Slack, in-app)
6. **File attachment** with versioning and tamper detection
7. **Role-based access control** (RBAC) with admin/approver/requester roles

12.2 Enhanced Features (Should Have)

1. **Position-based route branching** (役職分岐) for skip-level approvals
2. **OR approval** where any one of multiple approvers can advance
3. **Batch approval** for high-volume processing
4. **Comment threading** on applications with notification
5. **CSV export** with search filter preservation

12.3 Key Differences from Requirements

Areas where your requirements differ from or extend freee's capabilities:

1. **Chat-based initiation:** freee uses menu-based forms; your AI-assisted chat input is unique
2. **Expiration status:** freee doesn't explicitly show 'Expired'; consider adding deadline enforcement
3. **Emergency routes:** freee lacks built-in emergency approval; your post-approval requirement is valuable
4. **Escalation rules:** freee relies on manual follow-up; automated 24h/72h escalation would be an improvement
5. **Detailed audit logs:** Enterprise-level logging in freee; ensure similar IP/UA/diff tracking

— End of Report —